



FARM · FLOCK · FLOWERS

Hatching Chicken Eggs

A DAY-BY-DAY GUIDE FROM SETTING TO HATCH

It takes about **21 days** for a chick to hatch. Get the temperature, the humidity and the turning right, and the eggs do the rest. Follow these steps in order.

Step 1 · Get the incubator ready

- Set the incubator up **1-2 days before** the eggs go in — like warming an oven.
- Target temperature: **99-102°F**.
- Target humidity: **45-55%**. Check it with a digital hygrometer.
- Make sure there is good airflow — developing chicks need fresh air.
- Clean and sanitize the incubator before the eggs go in.

Tip: Run the empty incubator for a full day first and watch that the temperature holds steady before you trust it with eggs.

Step 2 · Choosing and setting the eggs

- **Do not wash the eggs.** They carry a natural coating called the bloom that protects them from bacteria.
- Store eggs **pointy-end down** for 1-2 days before setting them.
- Mark one side of each egg with an **X** and the other with an **O** in pencil — that is how you keep track of turning.

Step 3 · Days 1-18: Incubation

TEMPERATURE AND HUMIDITY

- Hold **99-102°F** and **45-55%** humidity.
- Check both at least twice a day.

TURNING THE EGGS

- Turn **at least 3 times a day** — always an odd number, so the eggs don't rest on the same side every night.
- An automatic turner does this for you.
- Turning by hand: wash your hands first, and be gentle.
- **Stop turning on Day 18.** That is when lockdown begins.

CANDLING — OPTIONAL, BUT WORTH DOING

- Shine a bright light through the egg in a dark room to see what is going on inside.

- **Day 7:** a dark spot with fine veins running out from it — that is a live embryo.
- **Day 14:** the embryo fills most of the egg and the air cell is easy to see.
- Pull any clear eggs (never fertile) or any showing a blood ring (stopped developing).

Tip: Candle in a dark room for the best view. A good flashlight works as well as anything sold for the job.

Step 4 · Day 18: Lockdown

CRITICAL PHASE

What you do in these last three days decides how many chicks make it out of the shell.

- **Stop turning.** Lay the eggs on their sides in the hatching tray.
- Raise humidity to **65–70%** — this keeps the membrane from drying and shrink-wrapping the chick inside the shell.
- Do not open the incubator during lockdown unless you absolutely have to.
- Add water through the outside ports if your incubator has them, so the lid stays shut.
- Keep an eye on temperature — it still needs to hold.

Step 5 · Days 19–21: Hatching

- Around **Day 19–20**, watch for a **pip** — the chick's first break in the shell.
- **Internal pip:** the chick breaks into the air cell. You may hear chirping before you see anything.
- **External pip:** a small hole or crack on the outside of the shell.
- From the first pip, a full hatch can take **12–24 hours or more**. Be patient.
- **Do not help** unless a chick has been stuck for 24+ hours and is clearly in distress — helping too early usually kills them.
- Do not open the incubator while chicks are hatching. The humidity drop can shrink-wrap the eggs that haven't pipped yet.
- Leave newly hatched chicks inside for **12–24 hours** to dry off and fluff up.

Step 6 · After the hatch

- Move dry, fluffy chicks to a brooder held at **95°F** for the first week.
- Give chick starter crumbles and fresh water right away.
- Drop the brooder temperature **5°F each week** until they are feathered out, around 6 weeks.
- Chicks absorb the yolk before hatching and can go 2–3 days without food — there is no rush if a few are still hatching.
- Clean and sanitize the incubator once the hatch is finished.

Tips for a good hatch

- Use a **digital** thermometer and hygrometer. Analog dials are not accurate enough.
- Keep the incubator out of direct sun, away from drafts and heater vents.
- Keep a hatch log – temperature, humidity and what you see, every day.
- Humidity matters as much as temperature. Don't ignore it.
- Don't overcrowd. Eggs need space and airflow.
- Fresh farm eggs hatch at **80–90%**. Shipped eggs run **50–70%** – that is normal.

QUICK REFERENCE

PHASE	DAYS	TEMPERATURE	HUMIDITY	KEY TASK
Incubation	1-18	99-102°F	45-55%	Turn eggs 3× a day
Lockdown	18	99-102°F	65-70%	Stop turning
Hatching	19-21	99-102°F	65-70%	Leave the lid shut
Brooder	After hatch	Start at 95°F	—	Feed and water

Happy hatching.

(559) 836-2880 · connect@melloacres.com · melloacres.com

Mello Acres · Michelle Mello · Hanford, California